

GitHub API Field Guide

The GitHub API stops working quietly: a list that returns thirty items, a webhook failing for a month, a 403 with no Retry-After. Every script here is read only.

64 fixes, each one a written note with diagrams and a small Python and Node.js script that finds the problem and repairs it. All 64 have a script in the public repo.

Before you run anything. Every script starts in a dry run: it reports what it would change and writes nothing. Read that output first, then set `DRY_RUN=false` when you are satisfied it has understood your data.

Scripts: github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes

Guides: allanninal.dev/github

All 14 repos: github.com/allanninal

The fixes

1 a permission error is disguised as 404 Not Found

The repository is open in a browser tab in front of you. The script asks for the same repository and gets 404 {"message": "Not Found"}. Somebody checks the spelling, then the owner name, then the case of both, then writes a ticket saying the API is broken. The API is not broken. It is refusing to tell you that the repository exists, because telling you would leak the existence of a private repository to a credential that has no business knowing about it.

[github_404_triage.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/404-masking-403/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/404-masking-403>

2 GITHUB_TOKEN gets 1,000 an hour, shared across the repo

The script works on your laptop. It makes about 1,400 calls, finishes in two minutes, and nobody thinks about it again until it is moved into a workflow. There it gets to roughly call 1,000 and starts collecting 403. Same code, same repository, same endpoints. The only thing that changed is which credential is in the environment, and that credential was handed a ceiling a fifth the size of the one you tested against.

[github_actions_token_budget.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/actions-token-repo-scoped-limit/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/actions-token-repo-scoped-limit>

3 a hardcoded installation id stops matching reality

The installation id was copied out of a settings URL in 2024 and pasted into an environment variable, where it has sat ever since. Last Tuesday an admin at one customer uninstalled the App during a security review and put it straight back, which they were entitled to do and which nobody told you about. Since then the token call for that customer has returned 404, and the error says nothing about installations.

[github_installation_id_drift.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/app-installation-id-hardcoded/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/app-installation-id-hardcoded>

4 a 404 that means the App is not installed on that repo

The repository is public. You can open it in a browser without logging in. The App reads eleven other repositories in the same organization with the same token, and this one comes back 404 Not Found. So the search starts with permissions, and permissions are not the problem, because the App was never installed here at all.

[github_app_installation_presence.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/app-not-installed-on-repo/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/app-not-installed-on-repo>

5 the App was never subscribed to the event it waits for

The handler was written, unit tested against a payload fixture, code reviewed and shipped. In production it has never run. Not once, not slowly, not with an error — the delivery log has thousands of entries and none of them is that event. There is nothing to debug, because nothing happened.

[github_app_event_subscriptions.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/app-not-subscribed-to-event/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/app-not-subscribed-to-event>

6 resource not accessible by integration on one endpoint

Nineteen endpoints work. The twentieth returns 403 {"message": "Resource not accessible by integration"}, which names no permission, no resource and no level, and reads like a platform bug rather than a configuration one. It is the one failure in this cluster where GitHub actually tells you the answer: it is in the x-accepted-github-permissions response header on that very 403, which almost no HTTP client shows you by default.

[github_app_permission_diff.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/app-permission-missing/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/app-permission-missing>

7 a new App permission that installers never accepted

The permission was added a fortnight ago. The App's settings page shows it, the pull request that used it was merged, and the feature works — for about two thirds of customers. The rest still get 403 {"message": "Resource not accessible by integration"} on exactly the call the permission was added for, and there is no pattern in which ones. Big orgs and small, old installs and new.

[github_permission_upgrade_lag.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/app-permission-upgrade-not-accepted/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/app-permission-upgrade-not-accepted>

8 the App's rate limit never grew with the installation

The App serves an organization with four hundred repositories, and it throttles like a personal access token. Somebody quotes the number they remember — Apps get more, Apps scale with the installation, we will be fine at this volume — and the plan was built on it. GET /rate_limit says 5000, the same as the laptop script it replaced.

[github_app_limit_ceiling.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/app-rate-limit-not-scaling/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/app-rate-limit-not-scaling>

9 the installation token was narrowed below what the job needs

The App is installed on the repository. You can see the installation, the repository is in its list, the permissions are generous, and one job gets 404 every time it touches that repository. The other four jobs, using the same App, on the same repository, are fine. Nobody has changed the App in months.

[github_token_reach.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/app-token-scoped-down-too-far/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/app-token-scoped-down-too-far>

10 the GitHub App has no webhook URL configured

The App is installed on forty repositories, the permissions were approved, the event subscriptions are exactly right, and it has never once reacted to anything. There is nothing in the delivery log to read, no failures to group, no status codes to explain. Nothing is failing, because nothing is being attempted.

[github_app_hook_config.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/app-webhook-url-unset/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/app-webhook-url-unset>

11 401 Bad credentials on every endpoint, even public ones

401 {"message": "Bad credentials"} on every endpoint you try, including ones that need no credential at all. The token is right there in the environment, it was working yesterday, and the error names nothing: not the account, not the scope, not which of the six things that produce this message actually happened.

[github_401_provenance.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/bad-credentials-401/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/bad-credentials-401>

12 the client still sends a username and password to the API

401 {"message": "Support for password authentication was removed. Please use a personal access token instead."}. The reflex is to go and mint a token, which is right, and then to paste it where the password was, which is half right, and then to be surprised when a different call still fails. The credential was never the problem. The envelope was.

[github_auth_scheme_check.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/basic-auth-password-removed/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/basic-auth-password-removed>

13 **a classic PAT passed its expiry and everything broke at once**

The integration ran for eleven months without anyone touching it. At 09:14 on a Tuesday every call started returning 401 Bad credentials, all at once, on every endpoint, with no deploy, no repository change and no org announcement. A classic personal access token reached its expiry date. So did a great many other theories that morning, and the API will not tell you which one was right.

[github_credential_differential.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/classic-pat-expired/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/classic-pat-expired>

14 **code search is billed to its own 10 a minute bucket**

The script walks the org, calling GET /search/code once per repository. It gets through nine of them. The tenth returns 403, and GET /rate_limit says you have 4,987 requests left in the hour. Both statements are correct, because the request that was refused was never being counted in the bucket you just looked at.

[github_code_search_budget.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/code-search-bucket-exhausted/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/code-search-bucket-exhausted>

15 **the compare endpoint stops at 250 commits and says nothing**

The release-notes generator diffs v4.2.0...v4.3.0 and produces a changelog that looks entirely plausible. It has 250 entries. The release contains 812 commits, and the ones it dropped are not the boring ones at the end — the shape of what came back is not what the code assumed at all.

[github_compare_truncation.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/compare-250-commit-cap/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/compare-250-commit-cap>

16 **the same webhook URL is registered on the org and the repo**

The bot comments twice on every pull request. Someone checks the receiver for a retry loop, finds none, and blames GitHub for sending duplicates. GitHub is sending exactly one copy of the event to each hook that asked for it — and two hooks asked, one on the repository and one on the organization, both pointing at the same URL.

[github_duplicate_hooks.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/duplicate-webhooks/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/duplicate-webhooks>

17 **the endpoint ignores page and returns page one forever**

The collector increments a page counter, exactly as it does against a dozen other endpoints, and every request comes back 200 with a full page of rows. It never finishes. Either it runs until something kills it, or it stops at an arbitrary page cap and hands over a dataset that is the same thirty records repeated forty times. The endpoint has been returning page one to every request since the first one.

[github_page_param_ignored.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/endpoint-ignores-page-param/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/endpoint-ignores-page-param>

18 **rotating the token invalidates every cached ETag at once**

The graph is a sawtooth and it is a very tidy one. Quota consumption sits near zero for fifty-odd minutes, jumps, and settles back, every hour, on the hour. Nothing in the schedule matches. The poller runs every thirty seconds and has done for months. What runs hourly is the installation token.

[github_etag_credential_check.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/etag-invalidated-by-token-rotation/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/etag-invalidated-by-token-rotation>

19 **the installation covers only some repositories, silently**

The scanner reports clean. Every repository it looked at was fine, every check passed, and the summary at the bottom says so. It looked at twelve repositories. The organization has a hundred and forty. Nothing errored, nothing warned, and no line of that report is untrue — the App installation was set to selected repositories at some point in 2023 and the other hundred and twenty-eight have never been inside its field of view.

[github_app_coverage_audit.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/installation-repository-selection-partial/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/installation-repository-selection-partial>

20 **the installation is suspended and every call it makes 403s**

Nothing was deployed and nothing was rotated. At some point on Thursday every call the App makes to one organization started coming back 403, and the webhook deliveries that used to arrive every few minutes stopped entirely. The App is still installed — you can see it in the list, the installation id you stored still resolves — and it does not work.

[github_installation_suspension.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/installation-suspended/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/installation-suspended>

21 **the installation token expired an hour into the job**

The migration ran for fifty-eight minutes and processed eleven thousand repositories. Then every request started returning 401 Bad credentials — not some of them, all of them, from one second to the next. Restarting the job fixes it, which is the detail that sends everybody looking for a memory leak. It is not a leak. The process outlived its own credential.

[github_installation_token_age.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/installation-token-expired/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/installation-token-expired>

22 **some endpoints refuse an installation token whatever it holds**

The App is installed. The JWT signs, the installation token mints, and nineteen calls in a row return exactly what they should. Then GET /user comes back 403 {"message": "Resource not accessible by integration"}, somebody adds a permission, every installer is emailed to accept the upgrade, and the same 403 arrives again the next morning.

[github_endpoint_audience.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/installation-token-rejected-by-endpoint/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/installation-token-rejected-by-endpoint>

23 clock drift puts the JWT iat claim in GitHub's future

The same code, the same key, the same App. On a laptop it works every time. In the container it returns 401 {"message": "'Issued at' claim ('iat') must be an Integer representing the time that the assertion was issued"}, and on the third host it works again until Tuesday. Nothing about the JWT changed between those runs. What changed is which machine did the signing.

[github_clock_skew.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/jwt-clock-drift-iat/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/jwt-clock-drift-iat>

24 a GitHub App JWT that expires in an hour is refused

The private key is right, the App exists, the signature verifies and the request still comes back 401 {"message": "'Expiration time' claim ('exp') is too far in the future"}. Three people regenerate the key. Somebody rewrites the signing code in a different library. The defect is one number, chosen three lines above the request, and it was wrong before anything was sent.

[github_app_jwt_claims.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/jwt-exp-too-far-future/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/jwt-exp-too-far-future>

25 the App JWT is signed with the wrong key or algorithm

It worked until the key was rotated. Now every call is 401 {"message": "A JSON web token could not be decoded"}, or occasionally 404 {"message": "Integration not found"}, and the two arrive from what looks like the same deployment. The key is in the environment. The App exists. Somebody has already pasted the PEM into three different terminals to check it looks right.

[github_app_key_identity.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/jwt-wrong-key-or-algorithm/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/jwt-wrong-key-or-algorithm>

26 only the first page is read because the Link header is ignored

The request returned 200. The JSON is a well-formed array of pull requests. Your audit read it, counted 30, and reported that the repository is tidy. There are 340 open pull requests. Nothing failed, nothing was logged, and the number you are now acting on is wrong by an order of magnitude — the answer was complete for one page and the rest was advertised in a header nobody read.

[github_link_header_audit.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/link-header-not-followed/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/link-header-not-followed>

27 the endpoint accepts a scope your token was never given

Nineteen calls work. The twentieth returns 403 {"message": "Must have admin rights to Repository."}, or worse, a bare 404 on a repository that is open in a browser tab beside you. The token is valid, it is not expired, it has not been revoked, and it is missing exactly one word from the list it was created with.

[github_scope_diff.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/missing-oauth-scope/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/missing-oauth-scope>

28 **polling without ETags spends full quota on unchanged data**

The dashboard polls eight endpoints every thirty seconds and burns through 5,000 requests before lunch. Almost nothing it fetches has changed. GitHub has been sending an etag on every one of those responses, and every response that comes back 304 Not Modified is free — it does not count against the rate limit at all. This is the one problem in this section where the fix pays for itself in a number you can print.

[github_etag_saving.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/no-conditional-requests/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/no-conditional-requests>

29 **one user revoked your app and only their token is dead**

One customer's sync has been failing since Thursday. Everybody else is fine. The token has not expired, because OAuth user tokens do not expire; nothing was deployed; the error is 401 Bad credentials and the retry loop has been dutifully re-attempting it every fifteen minutes for four days. The user clicked Revoke on a settings page you will never see.

[github_user_token_liveness.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/oauth-token-revoked-by-user/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/oauth-token-revoked-by-user>

30 **a read-only job holds a token that can delete repositories**

There is no incident to attach this to. The job runs every ten minutes, lists open pull requests, posts a count to a dashboard and has not failed once this year. The token it uses was created in four seconds by ticking repo, and it can force-push to every private repository in the organization, rewrite webhooks and delete the lot.

[github_scope_blast_radius.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/over-scoped-token/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/over-scoped-token>

31 **per_page is unset so every list costs 3.3x more requests**

The job is correct. It follows rel="next" to the end, it reads every issue, and it burns through the hourly quota by lunchtime. Nothing is broken and nothing needs debugging — it is simply making three and a third times as many requests as it needs to, because per_page was never set and the default is 30.

[github_per_page_audit.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/per-page-default-30/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/per-page-default-30>

32 **per_page above 100 is clamped and never rejected**

Somebody set per_page=500 to cut the number of round trips, and the request came back with exactly one hundred items and a 200. One hundred is fewer than five hundred, so the loop concluded it had reached the end and stopped. There was no 422, no warning header and nothing in the logs. Four fifths of the collection was never read, and the report built on it looks entirely finished.

[github_per_page_clamp.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/per-page-over-100-clamped/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/per-page-over-100-clamped>

33 **the x-poll-interval header is ignored on events endpoints**

The events consumer polls every five seconds because five seconds felt responsive. It gets the same page back seven hundred times an hour. On every one of those responses GitHub has been returning a header that says how long to wait before the next one, and the client has never read it.

[github_poll_interval_check.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/poll-interval-header-ignored/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/poll-interval-header-ignored>

34 **the integration polls for events a webhook would push**

The integration works. It notices new pull requests, it picks up comments, it has never lost anything. It also makes 4,320 requests an hour to do it, notices each of those events an average of thirty seconds after it happened, and would notice nothing at all if the poll ran once a day instead. There is no bug here. There is a design that was never revisited.

[github_webhook_vs_poll.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/polling-instead-of-webhooks/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/polling-instead-of-webhooks>

35 **core REST quota is exhausted and every call returns 403**

Every endpoint fails at once, with the same status, in the same second. That pattern says outage or bad credentials, and it is neither: the hourly bucket is empty, and an empty bucket refuses everything equally. The awkward part is that by the time you are reading the 403 the interesting question has already gone past. Not are we out, but at what rate did we spend it, and would that rate have fitted.

[github_quota_forecast.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/rate-limit-core-exhausted/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/rate-limit-core-exhausted>

36 **requests go out anonymous and are capped at 60 an hour**

It works on the first run and dies on the fourth. On a laptop it survives a couple of minutes; in CI, behind a shared NAT address, it is refused almost immediately and the run before yours gets the blame. Nothing in the code is wrong. The token simply is not arriving, and GitHub does not treat that as an error. It serves you anyway, as a stranger, from a bucket sixty deep.

[github_auth_tier_check.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/rate-limit-unauthenticated/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/rate-limit-unauthenticated>

37 **the Link header has no rel=last so the page count breaks**

The pager was written properly. It reads the Link header, it pulls the page number out of rel="last", and it uses that number to size the job before it starts: a progress bar, a worker pool over the page range, an estimate in the log line. On one endpoint the header comes back with a rel="next" and no rel="last" at all, and the job reports that it read one page of a one-page collection. It read one page of nine hundred.

[github_rel_last_absent.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/rel-last-absent/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/rel-last-absent>

38 **the client ignores retry-after and keeps hammering the API**

The log shows four hundred consecutive 403s, one second apart, for eleven minutes. The retry logic is working perfectly: it catches the error, waits, tries again, never gives up. GitHub said `retry-after: 120` on the very first one, and the client threw that header away along with the rest of the response.

[github_backoff_plan.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/retry-after-ignored/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/retry-after-ignored>

39 **org lists silently omit SSO-enforced organizations**

The user belongs to six organizations. `GET /user/orgs` returns four. Status 200, valid JSON, no errors array, nothing in the body that hints anything is absent. The two organizations that enforce SAML single sign-on for a token that was never authorized against them are simply not in the list, and the only place GitHub mentions it is a response header called `X-GitHub-SSO`.

[github_sso_partial_results.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/saml-partial-results/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/saml-partial-results>

40 **search returns at most 1,000 results whatever total_count says**

The response says `"total_count": 24831`. You page through it at 100 per request, and on page 11 the API returns 422 Validation Failed with `"Only the first 1000 search results are available"`. The count was true. The results were never there to fetch — `total_count` describes the match set, not the part of it you are allowed to page through.

[github_search_cap_audit.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/search-1000-result-cap/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/search-1000-result-cap>

41 **search has its own 30-per-minute bucket and drains separately**

The job loops over four hundred repositories and runs one search in each. Around the thirtieth it starts returning 403, and the part that makes no sense is that everything else keeps working: the repository reads in the same loop, on the same token, in the same second, are fine. Two buckets, and only one of them is empty. The error message does not mention which.

[github_search_budget.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/search-bucket-exhausted/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/search-bucket-exhausted>

42 **incomplete_results is true and the search answer is partial**

The same search runs every morning and the number it reports moves: 412 on Monday, 380 on Tuesday, 412 again on Wednesday. Nothing failed. Every response was a 200 with well-formed JSON and a sensible-looking list of items. The field that says the answer was cut short is sitting at the top of every one of those payloads, and no code in the pipeline has ever read it.

[github_search_incomplete.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/search-incomplete-results/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/search-incomplete-results>

43 **over 100 concurrent requests trips a secondary rate limit**

Someone replaces a for loop with a Promise.all and the job goes from nine minutes to forty seconds, once. The next run returns 403 on two thirds of the requests. You check the quota, because a 403 from GitHub means the quota, and the quota says four thousand eight hundred requests left. Both numbers are true. They are about different limits.

[github_concurrency_probe.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/secondary-limit-concurrency/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/secondary-limit-concurrency>

44 **bulk issue or comment creation exceeds 80 requests a minute**

The migration script imports 2,400 issues from the old tracker. It gets through about eighty of them, then every remaining call comes back 403. You check the quota and there are 4,900 requests left in it. The limit that stopped you is not counting requests. It is counting the things you created.

[github_content_burst_audit.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/secondary-limit-content-creation/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/secondary-limit-content-creation>

45 **a hot endpoint burns 900 points a minute and gets throttled**

One endpoint in the job keeps failing and the rest are fine. It fails for about a minute, recovers, and fails again twenty minutes later. The hourly quota is barely touched and the concurrency is one, because someone already serialised it after the last incident. What is left is the cap nobody budgets for: not how many requests you make, but how much work you asked one path to do inside sixty seconds.

[github_endpoint_cost_audit.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/secondary-limit-points-per-minute/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/secondary-limit-points-per-minute>

46 **the token expires in days and nothing is watching the clock**

Nothing is broken. That is the entire point of this note: it is the one that runs before the outage rather than after it. Somewhere in your environment is a credential with six days left on it, and the only thing standing between you and a 09:14 Tuesday is that nobody has read a header GitHub has been sending on every single response for months.

[github_token_expiry_watch.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/token-expiring-soon/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/token-expiring-soon>

47 **the token is passed as an access_token query parameter**

The call returns 401 {"message": "Requires authentication"} for an endpoint that plainly ought to work, and the token in the URL is correct — you can paste it into a header and watch the same call succeed. That is the small half of this. The large half is that the URL is now in an access log, a CI transcript, a browser history and a support ticket, and nothing about that half produces an error at all.

[github_token_in_url.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/token-in-query-string/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/token-in-query-string>

48 **a pinned X-GitHub-API-Version stopped being supported**

Nothing was deployed. No token was rotated, no permission changed, no dependency was upgraded. On a Tuesday morning every request to the GitHub API starts coming back refused, with a message about an API version, and the only thing that moved is the date. The header responsible was copied out of a documentation sample in 2022 and has not been looked at since.

[github_api_version_pin.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/unsupported-api-version/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/unsupported-api-version>

49 **a classic token nobody used for a year is deleted for you**

The restore drill is on a Tuesday morning and the token that has been sitting in the vault since the runbook was written answers 401. It has not expired, because it was created with no expiry. Nobody revoked it. It is not in the account's token list at all, because GitHub removed it for going a year without being used, and the reason it went a year without being used is that it is a token for emergencies.

[github_token_dormancy.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/unused-classic-token-auto-revoked/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/unused-classic-token-auto-revoked>

50 **every request 403s because there is no User-Agent header**

403 {"message":"Request forbidden by administrative rules. Please make sure your request has a User-Agent header."} — and it happens on the REST root, which any anonymous caller can read. Nobody looks at the body, because 403 in this API almost always means quota or permissions, and both of those theories send you somewhere the answer is not.

[github_user_agent_403.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/user-agent-missing/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/user-agent-missing>

51 **the hook sends form-encoded bodies to a JSON receiver**

The handler is written, deployed and subscribed to the right event. GitHub says the delivery succeeded. Your receiver says it got a request and found nothing in it — or says nothing at all, because it returned 200 having parsed an empty object out of a body it never understood. Every field in the hook looks right, because the field that is wrong is the one nobody reads.

[github_hook_content_type.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/webhook-content-type-mismatch/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/webhook-content-type-mismatch>

52 **webhook deliveries are failing and nobody reads the log**

Someone opens a pull request and the bot that should comment on it says nothing. You grep your receiver's logs for the last hour and find no request at all, which points the finger at GitHub. It is not GitHub. The delivery happened, your server answered 502, and GitHub wrote that down in a log you have never opened.

[github_hook_delivery_audit.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/webhook-deliveries-failing/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/webhook-deliveries-failing>

53 the hook is not subscribed to the event you are waiting for

The handler was written, reviewed, unit tested against a saved payload, and deployed. In production it has never executed once. There is no error anywhere because there is no failure anywhere: the hook was created years ago with push and pull_request, and the event your handler waits for has never been sent to it.

[github_hook_event_coverage.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/webhook-event-not-subscribed/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/webhook-event-not-subscribed>

54 the webhook posts your payloads to an http:// URL

The hook works. It has a secret, it is subscribed to the right events, the delivery log is a column of 200s, and insecure_ssl reads 0, which is the field the last security review looked at. The URL is http://hooks.internal.acme.io/github, so every payload and the signature that authenticates it have been crossing the network as plain text since the day it was created.

[github_hook_transport.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/webhook-http-url/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/webhook-http-url>

55 the webhook exists but somebody switched it off

The hook is right there in the repository's settings, pointed at the right URL, subscribed to the right events, with a secret set and a green tick beside it from the last time anyone looked. The delivery log is not full of failures. It is empty, and it has been empty for five weeks. Nothing is broken because nothing is running: active is false.

[github_hook_active_audit.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/webhook-inactive/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/webhook-inactive>

56 SSL verification is switched off on the webhook

The URL starts with https. The delivery log is clean, every attempt is a 200, and the hook has a secret so the payloads are signed. Everything a review asks about is green. One field in the same config object says "insecure_ssl": "1", which means GitHub has not looked at your certificate since somebody set that during the initial deploy in 2023.

[github_hook_ssl_verification.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/webhook-insecure-ssl/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/webhook-insecure-ssl>

57 a firewall allow-list no longer matches GitHub's hook IPs

Some deliveries land and some do not, with no pattern anybody can find. It is not the event type, it is not the payload size, it is not the time of day. The hook is configured correctly, the receiver is up, and the delivery log shows connection failures scattered among successes. Nothing is wrong with the webhook. The problem is a text file on a firewall, written correctly two years ago.

[github_meta_hook_ranges.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/webhook-ip-allowlist-drift/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/webhook-ip-allowlist-drift>

58 **a webhook with no secret sends no signature to verify**

The receiver has a signature check. It reads X-Hub-Signature-256, computes an HMAC over the body, compares in constant time, and returns 401 when they differ. It has never returned 401, because the hook it serves has no secret, so GitHub does not send the header, and the check quietly skips itself on every request.

[github_hook_secret_audit.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/webhook-no-secret/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/webhook-no-secret>

59 **the webhook secret is set and has never been rotated**

There is no symptom. The hook works, the signatures verify, the deliveries are green, and the secret that authenticates every event has been sitting in the same configuration file since the integration was built. It has outlasted two contractors, a laptop that was never wiped, and a support ticket where somebody pasted the receiver's environment into a chat window to get help.

[github_hook_secret_age.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/webhook-secret-never-rotated/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/webhook-secret-never-rotated>

60 **the receiver still checks the legacy SHA-1 signature**

The receiver verifies. It reads a signature header, computes an HMAC over the raw body, compares in constant time and returns 401 when they differ. It has been doing that since 2017, which is the problem: the header it reads is X-Hub-Signature, the SHA-1 one GitHub keeps sending for the sake of receivers exactly like this one.

[github_hook_signature_headers.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/webhook-sha1-signature-only/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/webhook-sha1-signature-only>

61 **the receiver takes longer than 10 seconds and times out**

The delivery log has started showing timed out against a handler that, according to your own logs, finished the job perfectly. It ran, it did the work, it wrote the record, it returned 200 — twelve seconds after it started. GitHub stopped listening at ten and filed the delivery as a failure, and the redelivery it may send will do the same twelve seconds of work again.

[github_hook_delivery_duration.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/webhook-timeout-10s/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/webhook-timeout-10s>

62 **the hook subscribes to every event with a wildcard**

The hook was set up in a hurry, with * in the events list, because nobody was sure yet which events the integration would need. That was two years ago. The receiver now handles four event types and is delivered somewhere north of forty, and every one of the ones it does not want still arrives, still gets its signature verified, and is still thrown away. Nothing has ever failed.

[github_hook_event_volume.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/webhook-wildcard-events/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/webhook-wildcard-events>

63 **a JWT sent as token, and the 401 blames the credential**

The App is registered, the private key is the right one, the JWT is freshly signed and it verifies in three different debuggers. GitHub answers 401 {"message":"Bad credentials"}. The credential in that request is perfect. The word in front of it is not, and the message never mentions words.

[github_auth_scheme.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/wrong-authorization-scheme/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/wrong-authorization-scheme>

64 **the automation runs as a person who can leave the company**

The release notes are signed by someone who left in March. Every automated review comment carries a colleague's avatar, every bot commit says their name, and none of it is a display problem: the token doing the work was minted on their account four years ago, so the integration is not running as a service. It is running as them.

[github_actor_identity.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/github/wrong-identity-token/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/github-api-fixes/tree/main/wrong-identity-token>
